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Starting Over

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Starting Over

Today's Reading: John 13:36-38

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Simon Peter said to him, 'Lord, where are you going?' Jesus answered him, 'Where I am going you cannot follow me now, but you will follow afterward.' Peter said to him, 'Lord, why can I not follow you now? I will lay down my life for you.' Jesus answered, 'Will you lay down your life for me? Truly, truly, I say to you, the rooster will not crow till you have denied me three times.'"

* * * * *

Jesus loved Simon Peter. He knew this disciple had a big heart for him. There was little question about Peter's devotion to the Lord.

But how Peter struggled with his flesh! He was so impetuous. Frequently he would speak before thinking. His emotions easily swayed him. That's why Jesus called him "Simon bar Jonah." In Scripture, "Jonah" is the same word for "dove." As a dove flies one direction and abruptly changes to another, so did Peter.

After Jesus' death and resurrection, Peter even fudged on the gospel of grace. He was in Antioch, eating with Gentiles—as he should have been. Then the Judaizers came to town. They were convinced that new believers needed to be under Jewish law and be circumcised, and they persuaded Peter of this. So he stopped having fellowship with Gentile converts.

Paul called out Peter publicly for his prejudice. Peter knew he was wrong and repented immediately.

Do you see the pattern? Even when you are filled with the Holy Spirit, your flesh can still be easily manipulated. Often your spirit is willing, but your flesh is weak.

Peter asked Jesus where he was going. The Lord told Peter it was a place he couldn't immediately come to. Later, he would be able to. Jesus was referring to heaven. Peter said he wanted to follow the Lord now and would even be willing to die for him.

Once again, Peter was being impetuous. He didn't understand the profound disappointment he would feel after Jesus' death, nor the antagonism, hatred, fury, and persecution that he would receive from the religious authorities. Jesus foresaw the future. He knew that Peter would deny him three times.

Peter and Judas behaved similarly. Judas was tempted by power and money and failed Jesus. Peter was tempted by fear and cowardice and failed Jesus. Even though their sins were different, they both betrayed the Lord in his hour of greatest need.

Though they behaved similarly, their responses were very different. Judas never repented. He felt sorrow for what he had done, but he never repented. Instead, he committed suicide. By contrast, Peter felt sorrow and repented. And Jesus, in one of his resurrection appearances, assured Peter three times of his unconditional love and forgiveness for him—one for each of Peter's betrayals. Their relationship was restored.

Repentance is the key. It stops the behavior that is breaking God's heart. It admits you are wrong and chooses to go in a different direction. If you return to the Lord and repent of your wrong, he will restore you. He loves to heal wayward hearts and give second chances.

Failure happens only when you fail to return to Jesus. His grace covers all sins—no matter how great or small, including Peter's. Including yours.

You can't sin beyond his grace.

[from "Hearing the Voice of God" by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]